

Pyrrhic peace: On the Hamas-Israel ceasefire

A united **administration** under the Palestinian Authority **must** be in place

After 15 months of war, which saw the deaths of tens of thousands of people, the **destruction** of much of Gaza and multiple rounds of **painstaking negotiations**, Hamas and Israel have agreed to a ceasefire. As soon as the news was out, thousands **ventured out** on the streets in Gaza, hoping that the daily **bombardment** and **shelling** would **come to an end**. Uncertainty still **lingered**, but both sides resolved their **last-minute differences** over details about Israel's partial **withdrawal** from Gaza and the names of the hostages to be released on day one and the ceasefire **came into force** on Sunday (January 19, 2025). This is not a permanent end to the war. But **given** the violence that Israel and Gaza have witnessed since October 7, 2023, even a pause in the war is a great relief, especially for Gaza's 2.3 million Palestinians. The agreement is expected to be implemented in three phases. In the first phase, Hamas will release 33 hostages, while Israel will release about 1,000 Palestinian security prisoners. The second phase would see more exchanges of hostages and **prisoners** and both sides are required to announce a permanent end to the **hostilities**. The third phase will involve discussions on the 'day after', including who should be in charge of Gaza.

As of now, both sides stay focused on phase one. Trouble could arise when **negotiations** for the next phases **begin**. When Israel launched the war, it set two objectives for itself — the destruction of Hamas and the release of hostages. In 15 months of war, Israel has **degraded** Hamas's **militant infrastructure**, but the group has survived and reinvented itself as an **insurgency**. According to Antony Blinken, the **outgoing** U.S. Secretary of State, Hamas recruited as many fighters as it had lost during the war. Israel's **inability** to destroy Hamas or secure the release of the hostages through the offensive **raises** serious questions about the IDF's military **tactics** in Gaza. This could probably be one of the factors that **persuaded** Benjamin Netanyahu to accept the ceasefire. But he has not **committed** to bringing the war to an end. **Hamas**, on the other side, **demand**s a complete withdrawal of Israel from Gaza. Despite the possible **roadblocks**, **the fact** that a ceasefire came into force **is** welcome news. It provides a **desperately** needed relief for Gaza and a platform to build further talks. **Israel**, Palestinians as well as the international **mediators** **should** now work towards **bridging the gaps** in the post-war **scenario**. Israel will not accept a situation that would leave Hamas as a **ruling** force in Gaza. A more **pragmatic** solution is to form a united administration of all Palestinian **factions** under the leadership of the internationally recognised Palestinian Authority, and then shift the focus towards the reconstruction of Gaza. But for this plan to work and peace to **prevail**, Israel should be ready to withdraw all its **troops** from the Gaza Strip.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **Faction** (noun) – Group, party, bloc, division, गट

Vocabulary

1. **Pyrrhic peace** (phrase) – A victory or resolution achieved at excessive cost, often leaving significant damage or losses
अत्यधिक कीमत पर मिली शांति
2. **Ceasefire** (noun) – Truce, armistice, suspension of hostilities, halt, peace agreement
युद्धविराम
3. **In place** (phrase) – Established, implemented, ready, operational, functional
लागू
4. **Destruction** (noun) – Ruin, devastation, obliteration, annihilation, wreckage
विनाश
5. **Painstaking** (adjective) – Meticulous, thorough, careful, diligent, exhaustive
सावधानीपूर्वक
6. **Negotiation** (noun) – Discussion, dialogue, talks, deliberation, mediation
वार्ता
7. **Venture out** (phrasal verb) – Step out, go forth, risk going outside, dare to leave, emerge
बाहर निकलना
8. **Bombardment** (noun) – Attack, assault, barrage, shelling, onslaught
गोलाबारी
9. **Shelling** (noun) – Bombing, artillery fire, mortar fire, barrage, cannonade
गोला बारी
10. **Come to an end** (phrase) – Conclude, finish, cease, terminate, stop
समाप्त होना
11. **Linger** (verb) – Remain, persist, stay, endure, delay
बना रहना
12. **Last-minute** (adjective) – Final, eleventh-hour, last-second, rushed, urgent
अंतिम क्षण का
13. **Difference** (noun) – Discrepancy, disagreement, variation, divergence, contrast
मतभेद
14. **Withdrawal** (noun) – Pullback, retreat, removal, retraction, disengagement
वापसी
15. **Come into force** (phrase) – Become effective, be implemented, start, take effect, be enforced
लागू होना
16. **Prisoner** (noun) – Detainee, captive, inmate, convict, hostage
कैदी
17. **Hostility** (noun) – Enmity, aggression, animosity, conflict, antagonism
शत्रुता
18. **Degrade** (verb) – Deteriorate, weaken, undermine, damage, erode
कमजोर करना
19. **Militant** (adjective) – Combative, aggressive, radical, confrontational, revolutionary
उग्रवादी
20. **Infrastructure** (noun) – Framework, system, facilities, foundation, structure
आधारभूत संरचना
21. **Insurgency** (noun) – Rebellion, uprising, revolt, resistance, mutiny
विद्रोह

22. **Outgoing** (adjective) – Departing, retiring, leaving, former, exiting निर्गामी
23. **Tactic** (noun) – Strategy, method, approach, plan, maneuver रणनीति
24. **Persuade** (verb) – Convince, influence, encourage, sway, prompt राजी करना
25. **Committed** (to) (adjective) – Dedicated, devoted, obligated, resolved, steadfast प्रतिबद्ध
26. **Roadblock** (noun) – Obstacle, hindrance, barrier, obstruction, impediment बाधा
27. **Desperately** (adverb) – Urgently, hopelessly, severely, gravely, critically अत्यधिक आवश्यकता से
28. **Bridge the gaps** (phrase) – Overcome differences, connect, reconcile, close divides, bring together मतभेद कम करना
29. **Scenario** (noun) – Situation, setting, context, circumstance, scene परिदृश्य
30. **Ruling** (adjective) – Governing, leading, dominant, controlling, prevailing शासक
31. **Pragmatic** (adjective) – Practical, realistic, sensible, logical, rational व्यावहारिक
32. **Prevail** (verb) – Succeed, triumph, dominate, persist, win जीतना
33. **Troop** (noun) – Soldiers, armed forces, military personnel, contingent, battalion सैनिक
- **Given** (preposition) – Considering, Taking into account, In light of, With regard to, Bearing in mind देखते हुए
 - **Mediator** (noun) – intermediary, arbitrator, negotiator, facilitator मध्यस्थ

Summary of the Editorial

1. **Ceasefire Agreement:** Hamas and Israel agreed to a ceasefire after 15 months of intense war and negotiations.
2. **Casualties and Destruction:** The war caused tens of thousands of deaths and widespread destruction in Gaza.
3. **Immediate Relief:** The ceasefire brought hope and temporary relief to Gaza's 2.3 million residents despite lingering uncertainty.
4. **Implementation in Phases:** The agreement has three phases—hostage and prisoner exchanges, permanent cessation of hostilities, and discussions on Gaza's governance.
5. **Phase One Details:** Hamas will release 33 hostages, and Israel will free 1,000 Palestinian security prisoners.
6. **Future Challenges:** Negotiations for the subsequent phases may face significant hurdles.
7. **Israel's War Objectives:** Israel aimed to destroy Hamas and secure the release of hostages but achieved neither fully.
8. **Hamas's Resilience:** Despite losses, Hamas has restructured itself as an insurgency and recruited new fighters.
9. **Military Tactics Questioned:** Israel's inability to meet its goals raised doubts about its military strategy in Gaza.
10. **Netanyahu's Decision:** Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu accepted the ceasefire but has not committed to ending the war permanently.
11. **Hamas's Demands:** Hamas seeks a complete Israeli withdrawal from Gaza.
12. **Ceasefire as a Platform:** The truce is an opportunity for dialogue and rebuilding efforts in the war-torn region.
13. **Post-War Plans:** Discussions on Gaza's governance post-war remain contentious, with Israel opposing Hamas's continued rule.
14. **Suggested Governance Model:** A united Palestinian administration under the Palestinian Authority is proposed for long-term peace.
15. **Reconstruction Focus:** For sustainable peace, Israel must consider a full military withdrawal, and international efforts should focus on rebuilding Gaza.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based

1. **Which factor is considered a reason for Benjamin Netanyahu's acceptance of the ceasefire?**
A. Complete destruction of Hamas
B. Israel's success in releasing all hostages
C. Israel's inability to destroy Hamas or secure hostages through offensive tactics
D. International mediators enforcing sanctions on Israel
2. **Why is the ceasefire considered a critical development for Gaza?**
A. It permanently ends the war between Israel and Hamas
B. It offers temporary relief and an opportunity for further talks
C. It ensures the release of all hostages and prisoners
D. It removes Hamas as the ruling force in Gaza
3. **What is the proposed solution to manage Gaza after the war?**
A. Hamas retaining power with international oversight
B. Formation of a united administration under the Palestinian Authority
C. Permanent occupation by Israeli forces
D. Establishment of a new Hamas-led government
4. **What can be inferred about the impact of the 15-month war on Gaza's population?**
A. The war has caused extensive suffering and disruption to daily life in Gaza.
B. Gaza's population has grown significantly despite the war.
C. Gaza's population was unaffected due to international aid.
D. The war strengthened Gaza's economic infrastructure.
5. **Based on the passage, what is a likely challenge for the implementation of the ceasefire agreement?**
A. Lack of international support for the ceasefire
B. Israel's refusal to release Palestinian prisoners
C. Hamas's inability to recruit fighters
D. Disagreement over a complete Israeli withdrawal from Gaza
6. **Sentences of a paragraph are given below in jumbled order. Arrange the sentences in the correct order to form a meaningful and coherent paragraph.**
A. However, when areas in Leh began to experience water shortages, life didn't grind to a halt.
B. Ladakh is a cold desert with a low average annual rainfall.
C. Thus, glaciers have been the main source of water for the people.
D. This was because Chewang Norphel, a retired civil engineer came up with the idea of artificial glaciers.
A. CBDA
B. BCAD
C. DABC
D. BCDA
7. **Select the most appropriate meaning of the given idiom.**

[Editorial page]

- Foul play
- A. Unfair or dishonest behaviour
 - B. A bad smelling theatre or playground
 - C. Unpleasant weather for playing
 - D. A drama which is badly produced
8. Select the option that can be used as a **one-word substitute** for the given group of words.
Formally put an end to a system, practice, or institution
- A. Stop
 - B. Destroy
 - C. Kill
 - D. Abolish
9. **The following sentence has been divided into parts. One of them contains an error. Select the part that contains the error from the given options.**
He was / late / for school / and punished
- A. for school
 - B. late
 - C. He was
 - D. and punished
10. **Select the most appropriate option to fill in the blank.**
She hardly works on weekends, _____?
- A. doesn't she
 - B. is she
 - C. does she
 - D. isn't she
11. **Select the most appropriate option to substitute the underlined segment in the given sentence. If there is no need to substitute it, select 'No substitution required'.**
I wish I were listening to my parents.
- A. am listening
 - B. have listened
 - C. No substitution required
 - D. had listened
12. **Select the option that expresses the given sentence in reported speech.**
Mother said, "Abhinav slipped while trying to board a bus."
- A. Mother told that Abhinav slipped while trying to board a bus.
 - B. Mother said that Abhinav slipped while trying to board a bus.
 - C. Mother says that Abhinav slipped while trying to board a bus.
 - D. Mother said that Abhinav had slipped while trying to board a bus
13. Select the most appropriate **synonym** of the given word.
DUO
- A. Bond
 - B. Pair
 - C. Loan

- D. Debt
14. The following sentence has been divided into parts. One of them may contain an error. Select the part that contains the error from the given options. If you don't find any error, mark 'No error' as your answer.
- It was a surprising / to receive the gift/ from my brother
- A. No error
B. It was a surprising
C. from my brother
D. to receive the gift
15. The following sentence has been divided into parts. One of them may contain an error. Select the part that contains the error from the given options. If you don't find any error, mark 'No error' as your answer.
- The fisheries sector / have grown significantly / in the last one year
- A. have grown significantly
B. in the last one year
C. No error
D. The fisheries sector
16. The following sentence has been split into four segments. Identify the segment that contains a grammatical error.
- My house / is more / spacious than / my sister.
- A. is more
B. My house
C. my sister
D. spacious than
17. Select the option that expresses the given sentence in passive voice.
- Do you trust me?
- A. Am I trusted by you?
B. Do I am trusted by you?
C. Do I was trusted by you?
D. I am trusted by you.
18. Select the most appropriate **synonym** of the given word.
- Paranoid
- A. Convinced
B. Trustful
C. Committed
D. Distrustful
19. Select the option that can be used as a **one-word substitute** for the given group of words.
- Indifferent to pleasure and pain
- A. Cynic
B. Stoic
C. Prudent
D. Lusty

20. Select the most appropriate **ANTONYM** of the given word.

Appal

- A. Alarm
- B. Assure
- C. Amaze
- D. Astound

Comprehension:

In the following passage, some words have been deleted. Read the passage carefully and select the most appropriate option to fill in each blank.

An old man lived in the village. He was one of the (1) _____ unfortunate people in the world. The whole village was tired (2) _____ him; he was always gloomy, he (3) _____ complained and was always in a bad mood. The (4) _____ he lived, the more vile he was becoming and the more (5) _____ were his words

21. **Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 1.**

- A. maximum
- B. utmost
- C. most
- D. main

22. **Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 2.**

- A. from
- B. of
- C. by
- D. at

23. **Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 3.**

- A. mostly
- B. commonly
- C. cyclically
- D. constantly

24. **Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 4.**

- A. long
- B. lengthy
- C. longer
- D. longest

25. **Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 5.**

- A. fatal
- B. mortal
- C. poisonous
- D. toxic

Answers

1. C 2. B 3. B 4. A 5. D 6. B 7. A 8. D 9. D 10. C 11. D 12. D
 13. B 14. B 15. A 16. C 17. A 18. D 19. B 20. B 21. C 22. B 23. D 24. C
 25. C

[Practice Exercise]

Explanation

1. C) The passage highlights that Israel's military tactics failed to achieve its objectives of destroying Hamas and releasing hostages. This failure likely influenced Netanyahu's decision to accept the ceasefire.
2. B) The passage highlights that Israel's military tactics failed to achieve its objectives of destroying Hamas and releasing hostages. This failure likely influenced Netanyahu's decision to accept the ceasefire.
3. B) The passage suggests a pragmatic solution where all Palestinian factions unite under the leadership of the Palestinian Authority. This approach would also involve shifting focus towards Gaza's reconstruction and peace efforts.
4. A) The passage describes the extensive destruction of Gaza and the desperate hope of residents for relief from daily bombardment. This indicates severe suffering and disruption during the 15 months of war.
5. D) The passage notes that Hamas demands a complete withdrawal of Israeli troops from Gaza, while Israel does not want Hamas to remain a ruling force. These conflicting objectives could create challenges during the later phases of the ceasefire implementation.
6. B) **BCAD**
 Ladakh is a cold desert with a low average annual rainfall. Thus, glaciers have been the main source of water for the people. However, when areas in Leh began to experience water shortages, life didn't grind to a halt. This was because Chewang Norphel, a retired civil engineer came up with the idea of artificial glaciers.
7. A) **Foul play** (idiom) – Unfair or dishonest behaviour अन्यायपूर्ण या असच्चा व्यवहार
8. D) **Abolish** (verb) – Formally put an end to a system, practice, or institution समाप्त करना
 - **Stop** (verb) – Cease to happen or continue; halt रोकना
 - **Destroy** (verb) – End the existence of something नष्ट करना
 - **Kill** (verb) – End the life of someone or something मारना
9. D) **and punished** के बदले 'and was punished' का प्रयोग होगा क्योंकि 'He was' Past Tense में है अतः 'punished' के पहले 'was' का प्रयोग जरूरी है; जैसे— He was late for school and was punished.
 In a compound sentence, both the auxiliary verbs and main verbs should be mentioned separately if they differ in number, form or voice.

- 'and was punished' will be used instead of 'and punished' because 'He was' is in Past Tense, hence, 'was' should be used before 'punished'; Like— He was late for school and was punished.
10. C) '**does she**' का use होगा क्योंकि 'hardly' का use negative sense में होता है, और जब sentence negative होता है तो positive question tag का use किया जाता है। 'Hardly' का अर्थ होता है "शायद ही" या "मुश्किल से", जो कि negative sense में है। इसलिए, 'does she' यहाँ सही है।
- '**does she**' should be used because 'hardly' conveys a negative sense, and when the statement is negative, a positive question tag is needed. 'Hardly' means "barely" or "scarcely", which carries a negative connotation. Thus, 'does she' is the correct choice here.
11. D) '**were listening**' के बदले 'had listened' का प्रयोग होगा क्योंकि 'I wish' के बाद regret या past के undesirable events के लिए 'had + past participle' का प्रयोग होता है।
- 'had listened' will be used instead of 'I were listening' because after 'I wish' we use 'had + past participle' to express regret or undesirable events in the past; Like— I wish I had listened to my parents.
12. D) Mother said that Abhinav had slipped while trying to board a bus
13. B) **DUO** (noun) – A pair; two persons commonly associated with each other, a couple. जोड़ा
- Synonym: Pair** (noun) – Two individuals that are considered together or are associated with each other in some way. जोड़ा
- **Bond** (noun) – A connection between people or things, a relationship, an agreement with legal force. संबंध
 - **Loan** (noun) – Something that is borrowed, especially a sum of money that is expected to be paid back with interest. ऋण
 - **Debt** (noun) – Money owed to someone; a state of owing money. कर्ज
14. B) '**It was a surprising**' में error है क्योंकि 'surprising' एक adjective है और इसे 'surprise' noun के रूप में correct किया जाएगा। सही वाक्य होता - "It was a surprise to receive the gift from my brother."
- There is an error in 'It was a surprising' because 'surprising' is an adjective and it should be corrected to the noun 'surprise'. The correct sentence should be - "It was a surprise to receive the gift from my brother."
15. A) '**have grown**' के बदले 'has grown' का प्रयोग होगा क्योंकि 'The fisheries sector' Singular Subject है और Singular Subject के साथ Singular Verb का प्रयोग होता है; जैसे— The boy has finished his homework.

- 'has grown' will be used instead of 'have grown' because 'The fisheries sector' is a Singular Subject and with a Singular Subject, a Singular Verb is used; Like— The boy has finished his homework.
16. C) 'my sister' में error है क्योंकि यहाँ सही तुलना के लिए 'my sister's house' या 'my sister's' का प्रयोग होना चाहिए था। वर्तमान रूप में, वाक्य तुलना कर रहा है 'my house' की 'my sister' से, जो गलत है। सही रूप में वाक्य होना चाहिए 'My house is more spacious than my sister's (house)'. अतः 'my sister' में त्रुटि है, जो कि विकल्प C में है।
- The error is in 'my sister' because it should be 'my sister's house' or 'my sister's' for a correct comparison. As it stands, the sentence is comparing 'my house' to 'my sister', which is incorrect. The sentence should be 'My house is more spacious than my sister's (house)'. So, the error is in 'my sister', which is option C.
17. A) Am I trusted by you?
18. D) **Paranoid** (adjective) – Exhibiting undue suspicion, worried, fearful, especially about being persecuted or harmed. संशयात्मक/ पागलपन-संबंधी
- Synonym: Distrustful** (adjective) – Skeptical, suspicious, wary, doubtful. अविश्वासी
- **Convinced** (adjective) – Completely certain about something. विश्वासी
 - **Trustful** (adjective) – Willing to trust people, naive, credulous. विश्वासपूर्वक
 - **Committed** (adjective) – Dedicated, devoted, pledged, bound. प्रतिबद्ध
19. B) **Stoic** (noun) – A person who can endure pain or hardship without showing their feelings or complaining. अडिग
- **Cynic** (noun) – A person who believes that people are motivated purely by self-interest rather than acting for honorable or unselfish reasons. दोषदर्शी
 - **Prudent** (adjective) – Acting with or showing care and thought for the future. सजग
 - **Lusty** (adjective) – Strong and healthy; vigorous. जोरदार
20. B) **Appal** (verb) – To greatly dismay or horrify, shock, disgust. भयभीत
- Antonym: Assure** (verb) – To inform positively, to give confidence to, comfort. आश्वस्त
- **Alarm** (verb) – To make someone feel frightened, disturbed, or in danger. चिंतित
 - **Amaze** (verb) – To cause great surprise or wonder, astonish. अचछंभित
 - **Astound** (verb) – To shock or greatly surprise. चकित
21. C) **Most** का use होगा क्योंकि जब हम किसी समूह में से बहुत अधिक व्यक्तियों या चीजों का चयन करते हैं, तो हम 'most' का उपयोग करते हैं। Sentence में कहा गया है कि वह व्यक्ति दुनिया में सबसे अधिक

दुर्भाग्यशाली लोगों में से एक था, इसलिए 'most' यहाँ सही है। 'Utmost', 'Maximum' और 'Main' इस context में सही नहीं हैं।

- **Most** should be used because when selecting a significant number out of a group, we use 'most.' The sentence indicates that he was one of the most unfortunate people in the world, making 'most' the best choice. 'Utmost', 'Maximum', and 'Main' aren't correct in this context.

22. B) **of** का use होगा क्योंकि इस context में "tired of" एक common phrase है जिसका अर्थ होता है किसी चीज़ या व्यक्ति से परेशान होना। जैसा कि पैसेज में mention किया गया है कि पूरा गाँव उस बूढ़े आदमी से परेशान था, इसलिए 'of' यहाँ सही है। जबकि 'from', 'by', और 'At' इस context में सही नहीं हैं।

- **'of'** should be used because in this context, "tired of" is a common phrase that means to be annoyed or bored with something or someone. As the passage mentions that the entire village was frustrated with the old man, 'of' fits here. Whereas, 'from', 'by', and 'At' don't fit in this context.

23. D) **Constantly** का use होगा क्योंकि "constantly" का अर्थ होता है लगातार या निरंतरता से। Sentence में mention किया गया है कि वह हमेशा उदास रहता था और हमेशा बुरे मूड में रहता था, इसलिए 'constantly' यहाँ सही है क्योंकि वह लगातार शिकायत करता रहता था। जबकि 'Mostly' का अर्थ है अधिकांश समय, 'Commonly' का अर्थ है सामान्यतया, और 'Cyclically' का अर्थ है चक्रीय रूप से, जो इस context में सही नहीं हैं।

- **Constantly** should be used because it means continuously or incessantly. The sentence mentions that he was always gloomy and always in a bad mood, making 'constantly' fitting here as he kept complaining all the time. Whereas, 'Mostly' means for the most part, 'Commonly' means ordinarily, and 'Cyclically' implies in a cyclical manner, which don't fit in this context.

24. C) **longer** का use होगा क्योंकि sentence में वृद्धता और व्यक्ति के मूड के बीच संबंध बताया गया है।

"The longer he lived, the more vile he was becoming" में दोनों घटनाओं के बीच संबंध को दर्शाने के लिए 'longer' सही है। 'Long' और 'Lengthy' यहां context में सही नहीं हैं क्योंकि वे अनुपातिक रूप में वृद्धि को दर्शाने में असमर्थ हैं। 'Longest' superlative degree है और इस context में उपयुक्त नहीं है।

- **longer** should be used because the sentence is drawing a correlation between the old man's age and his mood. "The longer he lived, the more vile he was becoming" utilizes 'longer' to show a proportional relationship between the two events. 'Long' and 'Lengthy' are inappropriate in this context as they don't convey a proportional increase. 'Longest' is a superlative degree and is not suitable in this context.

25. C) **poisonous** का use होगा क्योंकि "poisonous" का अर्थ होता है हानिकारक या जहरीला। Sentence में mention किया गया है कि जितना वह बुढ़ा होता जा रहा था, उतना ही उसके शब्द बुरे बनते जा रहे थे, इसलिए 'poisonous' यहाँ सही है। 'Fatal' का अर्थ है मौत का कारण बननेवाला, 'Mortal' का अर्थ है मरनेवाला या आवारा, और 'Toxic' का अर्थ है जहरीला, जो इस context में 'poisonous' से बेहतर नहीं है। 'poisonous' should be used because it means harmful or venomous. The sentence indicates that the older he became, the more harmful his words were, making 'poisonous' the most fitting here. Whereas, 'Fatal' means causing death, 'Mortal' means subject to death or temporary, and 'Toxic' also means poisonous but isn't as fitting as 'poisonous' in this context.

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